

HARROWING TASK Rescue workers carry a victim's body recovered from the wreckage

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coaches and rescue the screaming passengers inside. While the men were busy with rescue work, the womenfolk organised drinking water, biscuits and, later, cooked food till the official rescuers came.

Dattatraya B. Shinde, the collector and district magistrate of Balasore, cannot praise the villagers enough. "Hats off to the locals. They were there first, then came the DHH (district headquarters hospital) officials, the police and fire service," says the 2016 batch IAS officer who coordinated the rescue operations involving multiple agencies, from the National Disaster Response Force, fire service, Railway Protection Force, local organisations, the Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force to the army. "Provisioning for everyone, assigning them specific duties and arranging everything, from cutters to cranes to vehicles, was our priority," adds the sleep-deprived Shinde. Sagarika Nath, the Balasore superintendent of police, also commends the locals. "They handed us the wallets, mobile phones and other belongings that they had recovered," she says. "We set up a local 'lost and found' centre for the purpose. Over 500 mobile phones and 100-odd wallets were recovered."

Official help, from the local police to the Apada Mitras, arrived as fast as they could.

VILLAGERS FROM BOTH SIDES OF THE STATION RUSHED TO THE SPOT. UNDER THE LIGHT OF CELLPHONE TORCHES, THEY PULLED PEOPLE OUT OF THE MANGLED COACHES

"We got 100 ambulances within three hours and also involved the local four-wheelers. The injured were sent to the nearby hospital as fast as possible," says Shinde. By morning, relatives from different parts of West Bengal, Odisha and Jharkhand started trickling in, desperately looking for their dear ones amid the piles of dead bodies.

Dr Mrutyunjay Mishra, the district public health officer in Balasore, was part of the team that reached the accident site first. "Three doctors—the chief district medical officer Dr Dulalsen Jagatdeo, myself and another surgeon—and a first-aid team of eight pharmacists reached the spot in half an hour," he says, as he explains the emergency response of the DHH. Four days after the accident, the tension had finally eased for the doctors.

Shinde, who still uses a makeshift tent at the accident site as his office, says, "A temporary autopsy centre was started at the Bahanaga High School, the closest to the site. To preserve the bodies, we arranged six tonnes of ice from the fish processing units. Once relatives identified bodies, we started handing them over. Unidentified bodies were sent to the mortuaries at AIIMS and KIIMS in Bhubaneswar where the identification process is still on."

Siddheswar B. Bondar, the collector of neighbouring Bhadrak district, recounts a similar SOP. "We got 106 of the injured, out of which three arrived dead. Serious patients were referred to the SCB Medical College in Cuttack. All our patients have now been discharged," he says.

The day after the accident, the locals and organisations such as actor Sonu Sood's Balasore unit were at the hospital feeding patients and their kin, and donating blood. "We mounted a massive operation to distribute cooked food to about 565 people with the help of local organisations on the first day," says Girija Shankar Das, president, Balasore Station Club.

Then there are the survivors who are still in a state of shock. Jitendra Nayak, 29, who boarded from Balasore, was in the sleeper coach right behind the engine of the Coromandel Express that rammed into the goods train. "The coach was jam-packed and I was sitting on the floor. Some 25 minutes into the journey, a severe jolt hit me and I felt like I was inside a concrete mixer. I lost consciousness...when I came to, I was in Balasore hospital." He was to join as a supervisor in a Chennai glass factory but has lost the bag that had all his certificates.

Meanwhile, how the massive rescue operation and track restoration work was mounted is itself mind-boggling. Union railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw camped at the site with cabinet colleague Dharmendra Pradhan and senior officials till the tracks were cleared on the night of June 4. Anup K. Satpathy, divisional railway manager, Waltair division, who had joined the efforts with a 500-strong team, says, "The down and up lines were opened for traffic in record time."

Odisha's expertise in handling natural disasters also came in handy. Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik assigned responsibilities to 10 secretary-level officials and monitored the situation personally at the state control room on June 2. "Odisha has invested hugely in disaster preparedness over the past 20 years," says Sudhanshu Sarangi, director-general, fire services. "So we had the resources. Any other state would have been overwhelmed. There's even a sense of pride that Odisha handled such a huge disaster efficiently." ■